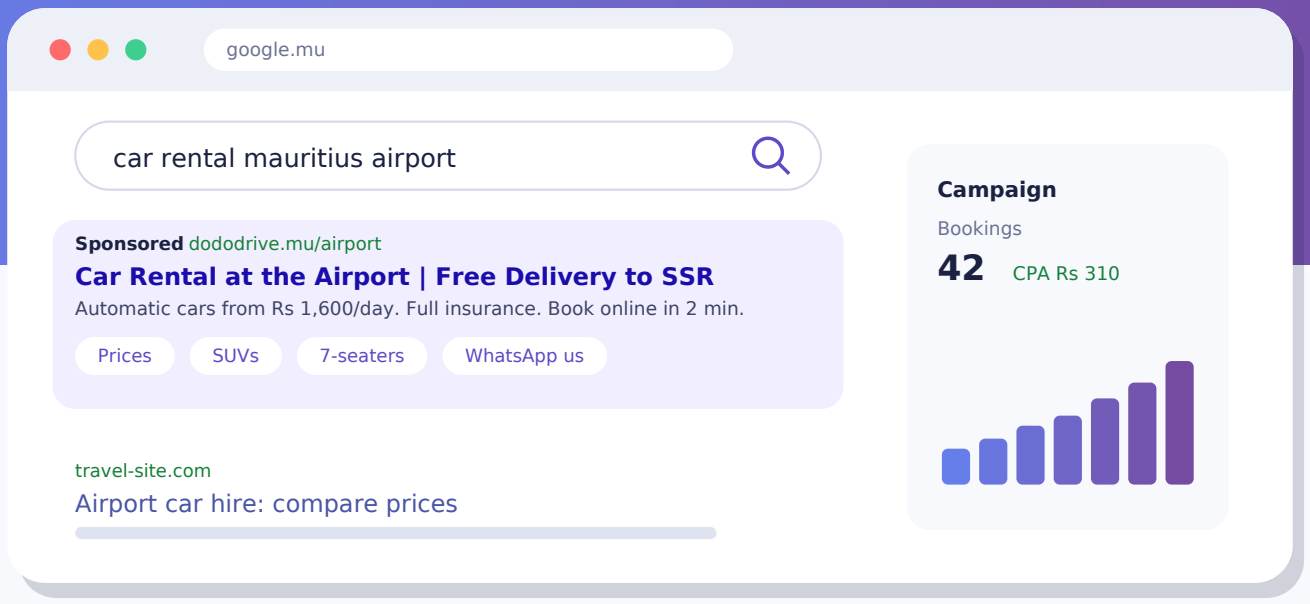
WEEK 6 · DIGITAL MARKETING & AI BOOTCAMP

Google Ads: Search Fundamentals

Accounts, keywords, ads, bids and budgets: your first search campaign in Mauritius, step by step

Avinesh Bundhoo & Fareez Fawdar · Oreegami Mauritius · October 2026



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PART A

Foundations

What Google Ads is, where ads appear, how the auction works and search in Mauritius

SECTION 1

What Google Ads is

Google Ads is Google's advertising platform. With a **Search campaign**, your text ad appears when someone searches on Google for words linked to your business. You choose the searches (keywords), write the ads, set a budget and pay only when someone clicks. This model is called **PPC** (pay-per-click).

Why search ads are different

On social media (Week 5) you interrupt people who are scrolling. On Google, people come to you: they type exactly what they need, often at the moment they are ready to act. "Plumber Curepipe urgent" or "car rental airport Mauritius" are not people looking for entertainment: they are customers with a problem to solve today. This is called **intent**, and it is why search ads are often the fastest way for a small business to get enquiries.

	SEO (Week 3)	Google Ads (this week)
How you appear	Organic results, earned with content and authority	Ads marked "Sponsored", bought in an auction
Cost	Time and content; no cost per click	You pay for each click
Speed	Months	Within hours of approval
Control	Low: Google decides what ranks	High: keywords, text, budget, places, hours
When it stops	Keeps working for a long time	Stops when the budget stops
Best use	Long-term visibility and trust	Immediate demand, tests, seasonal offers

The best results come from using both: Google Ads brings leads now and tells you which keywords convert; SEO builds the free traffic that lowers your costs over time. Search Console (Week 3) and Google Ads can even be compared side by side once they are linked (Section 9).

The vocabulary you need from day one

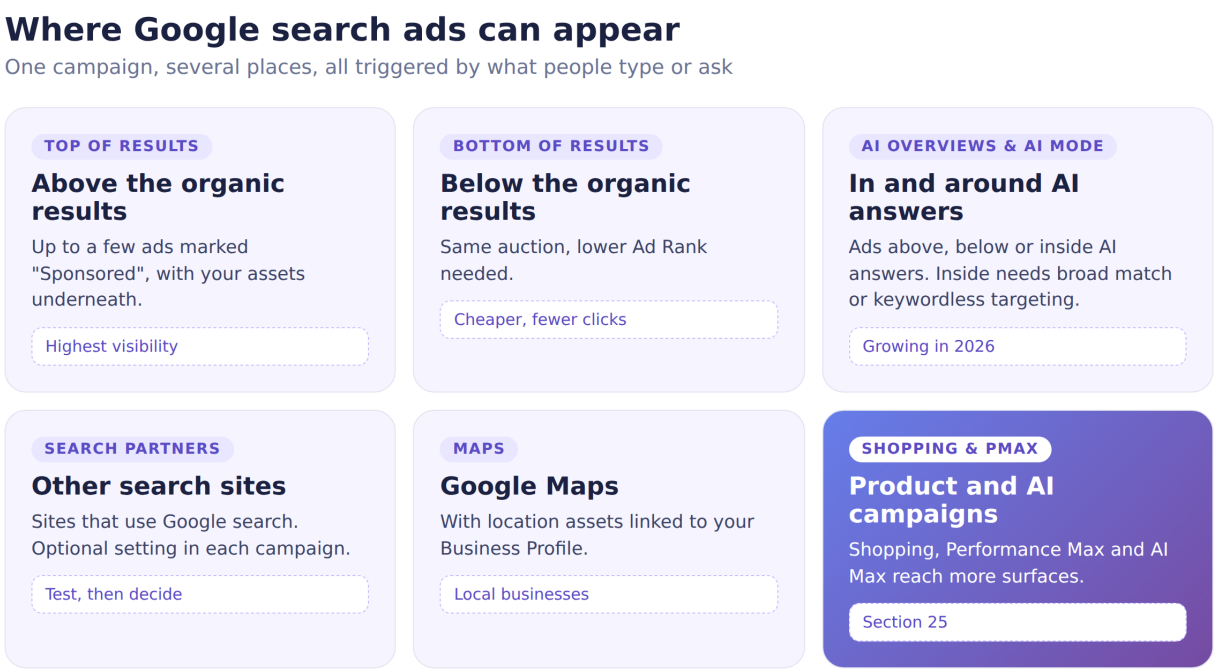
Term	Meaning
Impression	Your ad was shown once
Click	Someone clicked the ad
CTR (click-through rate)	Clicks ÷ impressions. 50 clicks from 1,000 impressions = 5%
CPC (cost per click)	Cost ÷ clicks. Rs 2,500 for 100 clicks = Rs 25 average CPC
Conversion	A valuable action after the click: booking, form, call, WhatsApp message
Conversion rate (CVR)	Conversions ÷ clicks. 8 bookings from 100 clicks = 8%
CPA (cost per acquisition)	Cost ÷ conversions. Rs 2,500 for 8 bookings = Rs 313
ROAS (return on ad spend)	Conversion value ÷ cost. Rs 72,000 of bookings for Rs 2,500 = 28.8 (or 2,880%)

> **Tip:** learn these five formulas by heart: CTR = clicks ÷ impressions; CPC = cost ÷ clicks; CVR = conversions ÷ clicks; CPA = cost ÷ conversions; ROAS = value ÷ cost. Section 24 and the Excel exercise use all of them.

SECTION 2

Where your ads appear

A Search campaign is triggered by searches, but the ad can appear in more places than the classic list of blue links.



What a search ad looks like

- A **"Sponsored"** label, then the business name, logo and display URL (for example dododrive.mu/Airport).
- A **headline** made of up to three short headlines joined together.
- A **description** of one or two lines.
- **Assets** underneath: sitelinks, callouts, call button, location, images, prices (Section 20).

AI Overviews and AI Mode

Google now answers many questions with an AI-generated summary. Ads can appear above, below or inside these answers. According to Google's Ads Liaison (2026), only **broad match** keywords or **keywordless** targeting (such as AI Max, Section 25) can show ads **inside** AI Overviews; exact and broad match keywords can both show ads above or below them. You don't need to set anything special to be eligible: it depends on your match types and campaign type.

> **In Mauritius:** a tourist planning a trip may ask Google "what is the best way to get around Mauritius without a taxi?". A car-rental business with broad match keywords and a good landing page can appear right inside that AI answer, a place organic SEO alone may not reach.

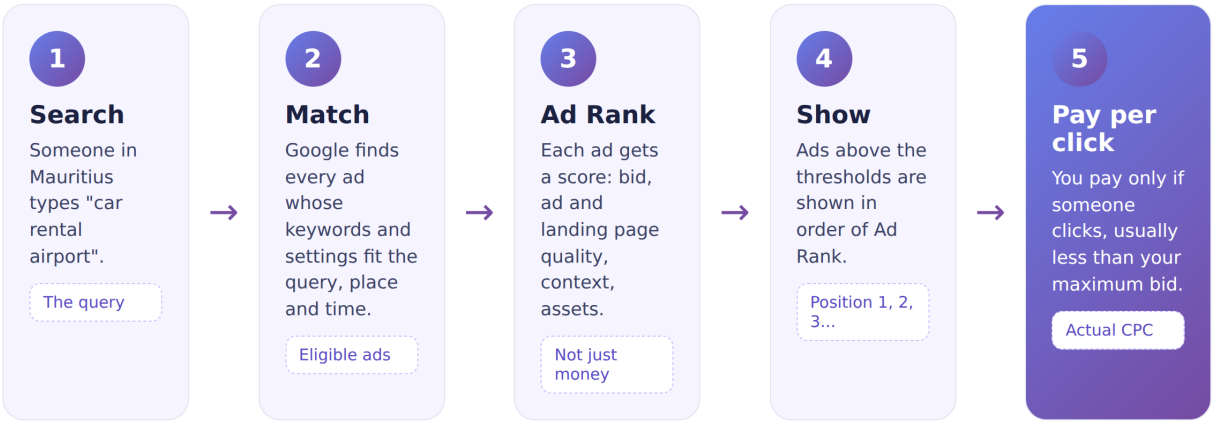
SECTION 3

How the auction works

Every time someone searches, Google runs a quick auction to decide which ads to show and in which order. The highest bid does not automatically win.

What happens in the 0.2 seconds after someone searches

An auction runs for every single search



Ad Rank: the score that decides your position

Google gives each eligible ad an **Ad Rank**. Google's help centre lists six factors:

1. **Your bid:** the maximum you are willing to pay for a click.
2. **The quality of your ads and landing page:** how relevant and useful they are (summarised by Quality Score, Section 4).
3. **Ad Rank thresholds:** minimum quality levels an ad must reach to show at all.
4. **Auction competitiveness:** how close competitors are to each other.
5. **The context of the search:** the words, location, device, time of day and other signals.
6. **The expected impact of assets:** how much sitelinks, callouts and other assets are expected to help.

What you actually pay

Your bid is a **ceiling**, not the price. Most of the time you pay less than your maximum, often just enough to keep your position above the next advertiser. Google also states that higher-quality ads can often lead to lower CPCs. In practice, this means a small business with a very relevant ad and a good page can beat a bigger competitor that simply bids more.

> **Simple illustration:** Lagon Bleu Guesthouse bids Rs 30 with an excellent, very relevant ad. A large hotel group bids Rs 45 with a generic ad sending people to its home page. Lagon Bleu can still appear above the hotel group and pay less per click, because Ad Rank is not just the bid.

Why it matters to you

- Relevance saves money: tight ad groups, keywords in your ads and a matching landing page (Sections 17–21).
- Assets are part of Ad Rank: always add them.
- Raising the bid is the most expensive way to improve your position: improve quality first.

SECTION 4

Quality Score: the basics

Quality Score is a 1–10 rating Google gives each keyword. It is a diagnostic tool, a little like a warning light on a car dashboard. Week 7 covers how to improve it in depth; here you need the basics.

Component	What Google checks	Ratings
Expected CTR	How likely people are to click your ad when it shows for this keyword	Above average, average, below average
Ad relevance	How closely the ad matches the intent behind the search	Above average, average, below average
Landing page experience	How relevant, useful and easy to use the page is after the click	Above average, average, below average

Two facts beginners often get wrong:

- **Quality Score is not used in the auction itself.** Google says so clearly: the auction uses real-time quality signals, and Quality Score is a summary that helps you see where to improve.
- **It is shown per keyword** in the Keywords table (add the columns "Quality Score", "Exp. CTR", "Ad relevance" and "Landing page exp."). New keywords with little data may show no score yet ("—").

Quick wins for a good Quality Score from the start

☐ One clear theme per ad group (Section 17).

☐ The main keyword (or close wording) in at least two or three headlines.

☐ A landing page about exactly that service, fast on mobile (Week 2).

☐ Strong reasons to click: price, offer, proof, call to action.

☐ Assets added at campaign or account level.

SECTION 5

Google Search in Mauritius

Mauritius is a small, very connected market where Google is by far the main search engine, and where two audiences search very differently: residents and visitors.

Indicator	Figure	Source
Population	About 1.27 million	DataReportal, Digital 2026 Mauritius
Internet users	About 1.01 million (79.5% of the population)	DataReportal, Digital 2026 Mauritius
Google’s share of searches	90.37% (September 2026)	StatCounter Global Stats
Bing’s share of searches	8% (September 2026)	StatCounter Global Stats

StatCounter measures page views from search engines on the sites that use its tracking code, so treat it as a strong indication rather than an exact count.

Two markets in one campaign plan

	Residents	Visitors and future visitors
Where they search	In Mauritius	Mostly abroad before the trip (France, UK, Reunion, South Africa, India, Germany...), then in Mauritius
Language	English and French, sometimes Kreol spelling	English, French, German and others
Typical searches	"plumber curepipe", "comptable port louis", "gym quatre bornes"	"car rental mauritius airport", "guesthouse trou aux biches"
Location setting	Mauritius, often a radius around your area	Their home countries, or Mauritius with "Presence or interest" (Section 12)
Example businesses	Accountant, plumber, gym, cake shop	Car rental, guesthouse, tours, restaurants

What this means for small budgets

- **Search volumes are small.** Keyword Planner will often show "10–100" monthly searches for local phrases. That is normal: a few dozen high-intent searches can still bring a plumber several jobs a week.
- **Competition is often low for local services,** so CPCs can be affordable. Tourism keywords searched from Europe are usually more competitive and more expensive.
- **Mobile first:** most local searches happen on a phone, and many end with a call or a WhatsApp message. Make those easy (call asset, click-to-WhatsApp on the landing page).
- **Bilingual by default:** run your keywords in English and French, and write ads in the language of the search (Section 12).

> **In Mauritius:** a plumber in Curepipe does not need thousands of clicks. Ten urgent calls a month from "plumber" searches within 15 km can pay for the whole campaign many times over. Start small, measure, then grow.

PART B

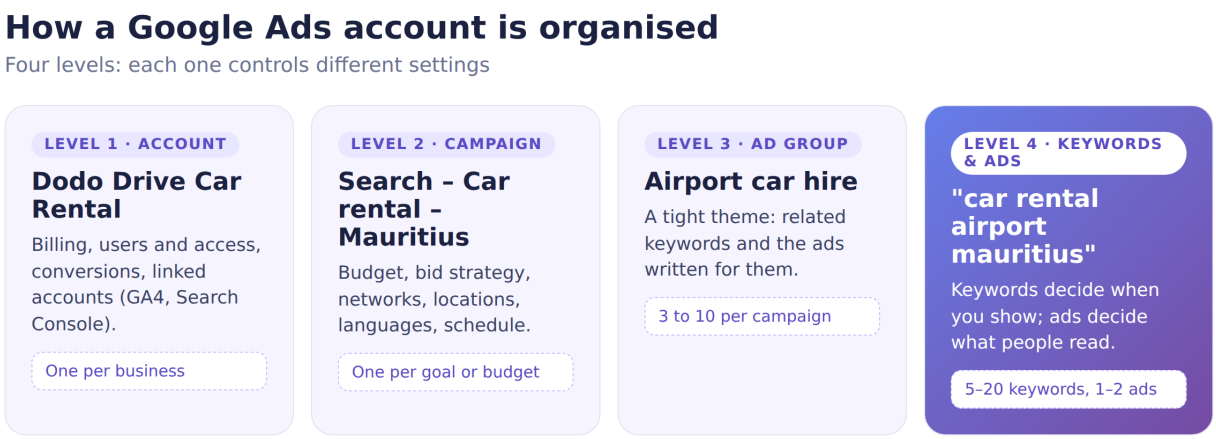
Account & tracking

How an account is organised, how to open it properly and how to measure what your ads bring

SECTION 6

Account structure

A Google Ads account works like a filing cabinet: the account is the cabinet, campaigns are drawers, ad groups are folders and keywords and ads are the papers inside. Getting this structure right is the single most important thing you do as a beginner.



Level	What you set here	Rule of thumb
Account	Billing, currency, time zone, users, conversion actions, links to GA4 and Search Console, account-level negative keywords and assets	One account per business
Campaign	Campaign type (Search), goal, budget, bid strategy, networks, locations, languages, ad schedule, campaign-level negatives and assets	A new campaign when the budget, location or language must be controlled separately
Ad group	A theme: a set of keywords and the ads written for them; optional ad group bid	One service or one intent per ad group
Keywords and ads	Match types, final URLs, headlines, descriptions, paths	5–20 keywords and 1–2 responsive search ads per ad group

A good starter structure for a small business

Most small Mauritian businesses need only **one or two Search campaigns** to start, each with **three to five ad groups**. Splitting into many campaigns with tiny budgets makes it hard for Google to learn and for you to read results.

```
Account: Dodo Drive Car Rental
 └─ Campaign: Search | Car rental | Visitors | EN   (Rs 400/day, Maximise clicks)
     ├─ Ad group: Airport car hire      → /airport-car-rental
     ├─ Ad group: Cheap car rental      → /prices
     └─ Ad group: SUV & 7-seater        → /suv-7-seater
 └─ Campaign: Search | Brand            (Rs 50/day)
     └─ Ad group: Brand name            → home page
```

When to create a separate campaign

- **Different languages or countries** with different budgets (e.g. French ads for France, English ads for the UK).

- **Brand searches** (people typing your name): they are cheap and convert well, so keep them apart or they make the other results look better than they are.
- **Very different services** with different budgets or targets (e.g. an accountant's "company set-up" service vs "personal tax return").
- **Different goals**: bookings vs job applications should never share a campaign.

Naming conventions

Use clear, consistent names, like the UTM rules from Week 2: **Type | Product | Audience/Location | Language**. For example "Search | Car rental | Visitors | FR". Six months later you (and your client) will thank you.

SECTION 7

Creating your Google Ads account

Opening an account takes ten minutes, but a few choices made on the first screens are hard or impossible to change later. Take your time.



Step by step

1. Go to **ads.google.com** and sign in with a Google account that belongs to the business (for example marketing@yourbusiness.mu), not a personal Gmail that leaves with an employee.
2. Enter the business name and website. Google will then suggest creating a campaign straight away, often a **Smart campaign**.
3. Look for the option to **switch to Expert Mode** (or to create an account without a campaign). Expert Mode gives you access to normal Search campaigns, match types, negative keywords and bid strategies.
4. Confirm the **billing country** (Mauritius), **time zone** (Mauritius, GMT+4) and **currency**. The currency cannot be changed later.
5. Add a payment method (Section 8).
6. Do not launch anything yet: first set up access, linking and conversion tracking (Sections 8–10).

Smart campaigns vs Expert Mode

	Smart campaign	Expert Mode Search campaign
Set-up	A few minutes, very guided	Longer: you decide every setting
Keywords	"Keyword themes" chosen with Google	Your own keywords with match types
Negative keywords	Limited	Full control
Search terms data	Limited	Full search terms report
Bidding	Automatic	All strategies (Section 22)
Good for	A very busy owner who will never log in	Anyone who wants to learn, control and optimise: this course

> **Watch out:** many small businesses in Mauritius discover months later that they have been running a Smart campaign with a vague keyword theme, sending clicks to their home page. If you take over an account, check the campaign type first (Campaigns table, column "Campaign type").

Manager accounts for freelancers and agencies

If you will manage ads for several clients, create a **Google Ads manager account** (formerly called MCC). It lets you access all client accounts with one login, while each client keeps ownership and billing of their own account. Never run a client's ads from your own account: the data and history would belong to you, not to them.

SECTION 8

Billing, VAT, access and verification

These administrative steps are boring but essential. They decide whether your ads run at all and who controls the account.

Billing in Mauritius

- Google's help centre lists Mauritius among the countries where **prepay is not available**: you use **automatic payments** (you are charged after your ads run, when you reach a billing threshold or on a monthly date), or monthly invoicing if your business is eligible.
- Use a **business card** that works for international online payments, and tell your bank: some cards block foreign charges by default.
- Add a **backup payment method** so ads don't stop if the main card is declined.
- Download invoices or statements each month from **Billing › Documents** for your accountant.

VAT on Google Ads

Since **1 January 2026**, Mauritius applies **15% VAT** to digital and electronic services supplied by foreign companies to customers in Mauritius, and "advertising space on a website" is among the services listed (Forvis Mazars Mauritius, KPMG). Check how VAT appears on your Google Ads documents and ask your accountant how to treat it, especially if your business is VAT-registered. Budget for it: a Rs 10,000 media spend may cost more once tax is added.

Access: never one owner only

- Go to **Admin › Access and security** and add at least **two admins** from the business (owner and manager).

- Give freelancers and agencies **Standard** access, or link their manager account, rather than sharing a password.
- Turn on **2-step verification** for every user.
- Remove people who leave the business the same day, as you would on Meta (Week 5).

Advertiser verification

Google is gradually asking **all advertisers** to verify who they are. You receive a notification with a deadline; you answer questions about your organisation and sometimes upload a document (for example a business registration certificate). If you miss the deadline, some or all ads can be restricted. Verified names and locations can appear in ad disclosures, and your ads are visible in the public **Ads Transparency Center**.

> **Tip:** prepare your company documents in advance: Business Registration Number (BRN) certificate, the director's ID and a recent utility bill with the business address. Use exactly the same business name as on those documents.

SECTION 9

Linking GA4 and Search Console

In Week 2 you installed GA4 and in Week 3 you verified Search Console. Linking them to Google Ads connects what people do before and after the click.

Link	What you gain	Where
GA4 ↔ Google Ads	Import GA4 key events as conversions; see Google Ads campaigns, costs and clicks inside GA4; build remarketing audiences	In GA4: Admin › Product links › Google Ads links. In Google Ads: Tools › Data manager
Search Console ↔ Google Ads	The "paid and organic" report: see where you rank organically and where you also run ads for the same searches	In Google Ads: Tools › Data manager › Search Console
Business Profile ↔ Google Ads	Location assets (address, map, distance) and Maps ads	In Google Ads: Assets › Location, or Data manager

How to link GA4 (the usual way)

1. Make sure you are an **Editor** (or above) in GA4 and an **admin** in Google Ads, with the same Google login.
2. In GA4, open **Admin › Product links › Google Ads links › Link**.
3. Choose the Google Ads account, keep **personalised advertising** and **auto-tagging** enabled, and submit.
4. Check in Google Ads that **auto-tagging** is on (Admin › Account settings). Auto-tagging adds a click ID (gclid) to your URLs so GA4 knows the visit came from your ads; you don't need manual UTMs for Google Ads.

> **In Mauritius:** if your client's website was built by an agency, GA4 may be on the agency's account. Ask for **Editor** access to the client's own GA4 property (or for the property to be transferred) before you start: it avoids weeks of delay.

SECTION 10

Conversion tracking

Without conversion tracking you only know what you spent and how many clicks you got, not what you earned. Smart bidding (Section 22) cannot work without it. Set it up before launch.

What to count as a conversion

Business	Primary conversion (what you optimise for)	Secondary (observe only)
Car rental	Booking confirmed (with value)	Quote form, WhatsApp click
Guesthouse	Booking request or confirmed booking	Clicks on the booking engine, email clicks
Accountant	Contact form submitted, calls of 60 seconds or more	Brochure download
Plumber	Calls from ads, WhatsApp clicks	Contact page views

Mark only the actions that really matter as **primary**: bid strategies optimise towards primary conversions. Keep the rest **secondary** so you can see them without misleading the bidding.

Two ways to track website conversions

	Option 1: Google Ads conversion with the Google tag	Option 2: import GA4 key events
How	Create a conversion action in Google Ads (Goals › Conversions › Summary › New conversion action) and fire it with the Google tag or Google Tag Manager (Week 2)	Mark the event as a key event in GA4 (Week 2), then in Google Ads choose New conversion action › Import › Google Analytics 4
Strengths	Most precise for ads; supports enhanced conversions	Fast if GA4 is already set up; one definition for all channels
Watch out	Must be tested with Tag Assistant	Small delays; GA4 and Google Ads can count slightly differently

Both are fine for beginners. Many advertisers import GA4 key events at first, then move their main conversion to a Google Ads conversion action with the Google tag. Never count the **same** action twice as primary (once from GA4 and once from the tag), or every booking will be counted double.

Calls, WhatsApp and values

- **Calls from ads:** when you add a call asset, you can count calls longer than a set duration (for example 60 seconds) as conversions.
- **WhatsApp:** track clicks on wa.me links as a GA4 key event with GTM (Week 2), then import it.
- **Values:** give each conversion a value, either fixed (an average booking is worth Rs 9,000) or dynamic (the real booking amount). Values unlock Maximise conversion value and Target ROAS later.
- **Consent:** if your site uses a cookie banner, consent mode (Week 2) lets Google model conversions from visitors who refuse cookies.
- **Enhanced conversions:** an option that sends hashed (scrambled) customer data such as an email address to improve measurement. Read the privacy rules and your own privacy notice first (Data Protection Act 2017).

Test before you spend: submit your own form, click your WhatsApp button and make a test booking. In Google Ads, the conversion action status should change from "Unverified" or "No recent conversions" to "Recording conversions" within a day or so. Then cancel any test booking in your own system.

PART C

Campaign & keywords

Settings that decide who sees your ads, keyword research, match types, negatives and ad groups

SECTION 11

Campaign goals and the Search campaign

When you click "+ New campaign", Google first asks for an objective, then a campaign type. Your choices shape the suggestions Google makes for the rest of the set-up.

Objective in Google Ads	When to choose it	Example
Sales	Online bookings or purchases	Car rental booking engine
Leads	Forms, calls, WhatsApp, quote requests	Accountant, plumber, guesthouse enquiries
Website traffic	Only when you cannot track conversions yet	A new site in its first weeks
Create a campaign without guidance	You know exactly what you want	Experienced users

Then choose **Search** as the campaign type, select the conversion goals to use (keep only your primary conversions, Section 10), add your website and give the campaign a clear name (Section 6).

Other campaign types you will meet

Type	What it does	In this course
Search	Text ads on Google search results, triggered by keywords	This week and Week 7
Performance Max	One AI-driven campaign across Search, YouTube, Display, Gmail, Maps and Discover	Introduced in Section 25
Demand Gen	Visual ads on YouTube, Discover and Gmail	Later weeks (display and video)
Display and Video	Banners on websites and apps; YouTube ads	Week 9
Shopping	Product listings with image and price, from Merchant Center	E-commerce weeks
App	App installs and actions	Not covered

Before you open the campaign builder: your plan

Write a one-page plan first. It is the start of your **Campaign Blueprint** (Section 29):

- ☐ Goal and primary conversion, with a monthly target (e.g. 40 bookings at a CPA under Rs 400).
- ☐ Who you want to reach, where and in which language.
- ☐ Three ad groups, each with a theme, 8–15 keywords and a landing page.
- ☐ Negative keywords list.
- ☐ Two ads per ad group and the assets.
- ☐ Budget and bid strategy, with the maths (Section 24).

SECTION 12

Networks, locations and languages

These settings decide who can see your ads. The defaults are designed to spend your budget, not to protect it, so check each one.

Networks

Option	What it means	Recommendation for beginners
Google Search Network	Google search results (always included)	Yes
Google search partners	Other sites that show Google search results	Untick at first; test later and compare results
Google Display Network	Banners on websites and apps when your Search campaign has budget left	Untick: use a separate Display or Demand Gen campaign if you want banners

New Search campaigns include search partners and the Display Network by default. Display clicks from a Search campaign usually convert far less well, and they make your Search results hard to read.

Locations

Choose where your customers are: all of Mauritius, a list of districts or towns, or a radius around your address (for example 15 km around Curepipe for a plumber). Then open **Location options**:

Location option	Who sees the ad	Use it when
Presence or interest (default)	People in, or regularly in, your locations, plus people showing interest in them (e.g. someone in Paris searching "car rental mauritius")	Tourism: you want future visitors searching from abroad
Presence	Only people in, or regularly in, your locations	Local services: plumber, accountant, gym, cake delivery

Exclusions always work on presence: excluding Reunion means people physically in Reunion won’t see the ad.

In Mauritius: for a guesthouse or car rental, two campaigns often work best: one targeting **Mauritius with "Presence or interest"** (visitors already planning, plus tourists on the island), and one targeting the **main source countries** (France, UK, Reunion, South Africa…) with ads in their language. A plumber in Curepipe should use **"Presence"** with a radius, or he will pay for clicks from people abroad.

Languages

The language setting tells Google which users can see your ads, based on signals such as the language of their search and their settings. Google does not translate your ads. In Mauritius, select **English and French** for most local campaigns and write ads in the language of the keywords in each ad group (or create separate English and French campaigns for tourism).

Tip: Kreol searches are usually typed with French or English spellings ("plombier", "ki pri"). Keep French selected and add those spellings as keywords if your research shows they are searched.

SECTION 13

Schedule, devices and budget settings

The last group of settings controls when your ads run and how much you can spend per day.

Ad schedule

By default ads run 24 hours a day. Limit the hours only when it really matters: for example, a plumber who answers the phone 7:00–19:00 may stop "call-only" demand at night, but a car rental with an online booking engine should keep ads running when tourists in Europe are awake (Mauritius is 2–3 hours ahead of France and 3–4 hours ahead of the UK).

Devices

Ads show on computers, phones and tablets. You can adjust bids by device with manual bidding, but with Smart Bidding Google adjusts automatically. Look at device results after a few weeks before changing anything.

Daily budget

In Google Ads you set an **average daily budget** per campaign. Two rules from Google's help centre to know by heart:

- On any given day, spend can be **up to 2 times** your average daily budget, to take advantage of busy days.
- Over a month, you are never charged more than **30.4 × your average daily budget** (30.4 is the average number of days in a month).

> **Example:** a daily budget of Rs 400 means up to Rs 800 on a busy Saturday, but never more than Rs 400 × 30.4 = **Rs 12,160** for the month. To spend Rs 15,000 a month, set Rs 15,000 ÷ 30.4 ≈ **Rs 493 per day**.

Other settings to check

- **Start and end dates:** useful for seasonal offers (e.g. December holidays).
- **Broad match setting / AI Max:** leave off for your first campaign; Section 25 explains when to use them.
- **Brand settings:** in some campaigns you can include or exclude brand names; useful once you understand your search terms.
- **Automatically created assets:** Google can write extra headlines from your site. Review what it generates if you leave it on.

SECTION 14

Keyword research with Keyword Planner

Keywords are the words and phrases you choose so your ads show for the right searches. In Week 3 you researched keywords for SEO; for ads you look for words that show **intent to buy or book now**.

Open Keyword Planner

In Google Ads: **Tools › Planning › Keyword Planner**. It is free once you have an account. It has two tools:

- **Discover new keywords:** enter words or your website and get ideas with average monthly searches, competition and top-of-page bid ranges (low and high estimates of the CPC).
- **Get search volume and forecasts:** paste your own list to see volumes and a forecast of clicks and cost for a budget.

Set the location (Mauritius or the target countries) and the language before reading the numbers: the defaults are often another country. In small markets you will often see ranges such as "10–100".

Five sources of keyword ideas

1. Your services and products, in the words customers use ("car hire", "location voiture").
2. Keyword Planner ideas from your website and competitors' websites.
3. Google autocomplete and "People also search for" (Week 3).
4. Search Console queries that already bring organic visitors (Week 3).
5. Your customers: the questions they ask on WhatsApp and the phone.

Sort keywords by intent

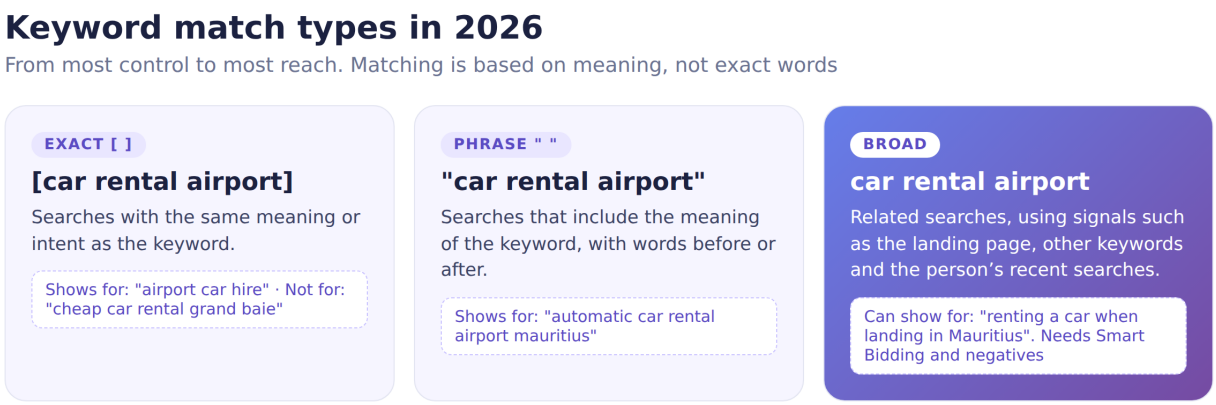
Intent	Example	For ads?
Transactional: ready to act	"rent automatic car mauritius", "plumber near me", "book guesthouse trou aux biches"	Yes: your core keywords
Commercial: comparing	"best car rental mauritius", "accountant fees mauritius"	Yes, with a strong offer
Informational: learning	"how to drive in mauritius", "how to fix a leaking tap"	Usually no: content and SEO (Week 4) instead
Navigational: a brand	"hertz mauritius", "avis airport"	Your own brand yes; competitors' brands with care

Trademarks: you can bid on a competitor's name as a keyword in many cases, but you must not use their trademark in your ad text if they have restricted it. It can also start a price war. Start with your own services and brand.

SECTION 15

Match types: how keywords match searches

The match type tells Google how closely a search must match your keyword. In 2026, all three types match on **meaning**, not exact spelling: plurals, misspellings, synonyms and reworded searches with the same intent can all match.



Match type	How to write it	Reach	Control	Best for
Exact	[car rental airport]	Lowest	Highest	Your best-converting searches; small budgets
Phrase	"car rental airport"	Medium	Medium	Most beginners' core keywords
Broad	car rental airport	Highest	Lowest	With conversion tracking, Smart Bidding and a strong negative list

How matching really behaves

- **Exact match** shows for searches with the same meaning or intent. [car rental airport] can match "airport car hire" or "car rentals airport", but not "cheap car rental grand baie".
- **Phrase match** shows for searches that include the meaning of the keyword, with other words before or after: "automatic car rental airport mauritius".
- **Broad match** can show for related searches without the keyword's words. Google uses extra signals: your landing page, the other keywords in the ad group and the person's recent searches. It is powerful with good data and risky without it.
- **Priority:** when a search is identical to one of your exact match keywords, that keyword is preferred over phrase or broad keywords and over Performance Max.

A practical approach for your first campaign

1. Start with **phrase and exact** match for your core keywords.
2. Read the search terms report every few days (Section 27) and add negatives.
3. Once conversions are tracked and you have at least a few dozen a month, test **broad match** with Maximise conversions in one ad group, or as an experiment.
4. Keep the keywords that bring conversions at a good CPA, whatever their match type.

> **Tip:** don’t add the same keyword in all three match types in one ad group "just in case". With today’s matching it mainly duplicates work. Choose one match type per keyword.

SECTION 16

Negative keywords

Negative keywords stop your ads from showing for searches you don’t want. They are the cheapest way to save money in Google Ads, and the most often forgotten.

Negative match type	Written as	Blocks searches that...	Example
Negative broad	jobs	contain all the negative words, in any order	"car rental jobs mauritius"
Negative phrase	"used cars"	contain the words in this order, extra words allowed	"used cars for sale curepipe"
Negative exact	[car rental]	are exactly these words, nothing more	"car rental" alone (too vague)

> **Important difference:** negative keywords do **not** match close variants. If you exclude "job", you must also add "jobs"; if you exclude "free", consider "gratuit". Add plurals, French versions and common misspellings yourself.

Starter negative lists for Mauritius

Theme	Negative keywords to consider
Jobs	job, jobs, vacancy, vacancies, emploi, recrutement, hiring, salary, salaire
Free and DIY	free, gratuit, diy, how to, tutorial, youtube
Learning	course, training, formation, pdf, definition
Wrong product (car rental)	used, second hand, occasion, for sale, a vendre, leasing company, driving licence, permis
Wrong product (guesthouse)	for sale, a vendre, land, terrain, long term rent, colocation
Wrong place	Towns or countries you don’t serve (e.g. rodrigues if you can’t deliver there)

Where to add negatives

- **Ad group level:** to send a search to the right ad group (e.g. add "suv" as negative in the "Cheap car rental" ad group so SUV searches go to the SUV ad group).
- **Campaign level:** words irrelevant to the whole campaign.
- **Negative keyword lists** (Tools › Shared library › Exclusion lists): reusable lists such as "Jobs" or "Free" applied to several campaigns.
- **Account level:** a short list applied everywhere, including some automated campaign types.

SECTION 17

Building ad groups

An ad group is a set of keywords with the same intent, the ads written for them and one landing page. Tight ad groups give relevant ads, better quality and clearer reports.

The test of a good ad group

Read the keywords of an ad group aloud. Could **one ad** and **one landing page** answer all of them perfectly? If not, split the group.

Weak ad group: "Car rental"	Strong: three ad groups
car rental mauritius, cheap car hire, suv rental, 7 seater car mauritius, car rental airport, automatic car rental, van hire	**Airport car hire:** car rental airport mauritius, car hire ssr airport, airport car rental pick up **Cheap car rental:** cheap car rental mauritius, budget car hire, car rental prices mauritius **SUV and 7-seater:** suv rental mauritius, 7 seater car hire, family car rental mauritius

Four Mauritian examples of three ad groups

Business (fictional)	Ad group 1	Ad group 2	Ad group 3
Dodo Drive Car Rental, Plaine Magnien	Airport car hire "car rental airport mauritius"	Cheap car rental "cheap car hire mauritius"	SUV and 7-seater "7 seater car rental mauritius"
Lagon Bleu Guesthouse, Trou aux Biches	Guesthouse Trou aux Biches "guesthouse trou aux biches"	Beach accommodation north "beachfront guesthouse mauritius north"	Chambre d’hôte (French) "chambre d’hôte trou aux biches"
Ramdin & Co Accountants, Port Louis	Company set-up "company registration mauritius"	Accounting for SMEs "accountant for small business mauritius"	Tax returns "income tax return help mauritius"
PlomboFix Plumbing, Curepipe	Emergency plumber "emergency plumber curepipe"	Leaks and repairs "water leak repair"	Water heaters "solar water heater repair"

Each ad group sends people to its own page: /airport-car-rental, /prices, /suv-7-seater; or for the plumber, /emergency, /leaks, /water-heaters. If the website does not have such pages yet, creating them is part of the job (Section 21).

How many keywords per ad group?

Between 5 and 20 is a good range for beginners. Fewer, well-chosen keywords are better than 80 loose ones: with today’s matching, Google already finds the variants.

PART D

Ads, assets & bidding

Writing responsive search ads, adding assets, choosing a bid strategy and doing the budget maths

SECTION 18

Responsive search ads

The responsive search ad (RSA) is the standard text ad in Search campaigns. You write several headlines and descriptions; Google combines them and learns which combinations work best for each search.

Anatomy of a responsive search ad

You give Google up to 15 headlines and 4 descriptions; it tests the combinations

HEADLINES

Up to 15 · 30 characters each

Minimum 3. Up to 3 show at a time. Include keywords, benefits, offer, proof, call to action.

Car Rental at SSR Airport

DESCRIPTIONS

Up to 4 · 90 characters each

Minimum 2. Up to 2 show. Explain the offer and give a reason to click now.

Free delivery to the airport. Full insurance included. Book online in 2 minutes.

DISPLAY PATHS

2 paths · 15 characters each

Words added to the visible URL. They don't change the landing page.

dododrive.mu/Airport/Automatic

FINAL URL

The landing page

The most relevant page for the ad group, not the home page by default.

dododrive.mu/airport-car-rental

PINNING

Use sparingly

Fix a headline to position 1, 2 or 3 only when you must (legal text, brand). It lowers flexibility.

Pin 2–3 options per position

AD STRENGTH

Aim for Good or Excellent

A guide to variety and relevance, not a ranking factor by itself.

2 RSAs per ad group

Element	Minimum	Maximum	Character limit	Shown at once
Headlines	3	15	30 each	Up to 3
Descriptions	2	4	90 each	Up to 2
Display paths	0	2	15 each	Both
Final URL	1	1	–	–

Limits from Google's help centre ("About responsive search ads"). Characters include spaces and punctuation.

Pinning

Pinning fixes a headline or description to a position. Headlines pinned to position 1 or 2 and descriptions pinned to position 1 always show; position 3 and description 2 may not show. Google advises against pinning for most advertisers because it reduces the combinations it can test and lowers Ad Strength.

- Pin only when you must: a legal line, a licence number, or the brand name in position 1 for a franchise.
- If you pin, pin **2 or 3 different headlines** to the same position so Google can still rotate them.
- If a keyword is longer than 30 characters, put it in a description, not a headline.

Ad Strength

Ad Strength (Poor, Average, Good, Excellent) rates how varied and relevant your headlines and descriptions are. It is a writing guide, not a direct ranking factor. Google recommends **at least two RSAs per ad group**, each with "Good" or "Excellent" Ad Strength. To improve it: add more unique headlines, include popular keywords, and avoid repeating the same idea in different words.

Ad customisers (for later)

Customisers insert text automatically, for example the keyword, the user's city or a countdown to the end of an offer ("Offer ends in 3 days"). They are useful but optional; master the basics first.

SECTION 19

Writing ads that get clicks

Your ad has about one second to convince. It must match the search, stand out from competitors and give a reason to click now.

The 15-headline formula

Type	How many	Examples (Dodo Drive, airport ad group)
Keyword	3–4	Car Rental at SSR Airport · Airport Car Hire Mauritius · Rent a Car at the Airport
Benefit	3	Free Delivery to the Airport · No Queue, Car Waiting for You · Full Insurance Included
Offer and price	2–3	From Rs 1,600 per Day · 10% Off Weekly Rentals
Proof	2	Rated 4.8 by 600+ Travellers · Family Business Since 2012
Call to action	2–3	Book Online in 2 Minutes · WhatsApp Us for a Quote · Reserve Your Car Today

All figures (prices, ratings, years) in examples are illustrative. In real ads, every claim must be true and checkable on the landing page.

Descriptions

- Free airport delivery and pick-up. Automatic cars, full insurance, 24/7 help. Book today. *(89 characters)*
- Land, smile and drive: your car waits at SSR Airport. Transparent prices, no hidden fees. *(89)*
- Compact, SUV or 7-seater for families. Pay online or on arrival. WhatsApp us any time. *(86)*

Writing rules

- **Match the search:** the keyword or its meaning in at least two or three headlines.
- **Be specific:** "From Rs 1,600/day" beats "Great prices"; "Plumber in 60 minutes" beats "Fast service".
- **Talk to the customer:** "your car", "your holiday", "your business".
- **One idea per headline**, so any combination still makes sense.
- **Speak the searcher's language:** French keywords get French ads.
- **Use Title Case or sentence case consistently**; avoid ALL CAPS, repeated punctuation and gimmicks ("!!!"): they break Google's editorial policy.
- **Use AI to draft, not to publish:** ask Claude or Gemini for 30 headline ideas, then check facts, length and tone yourself.

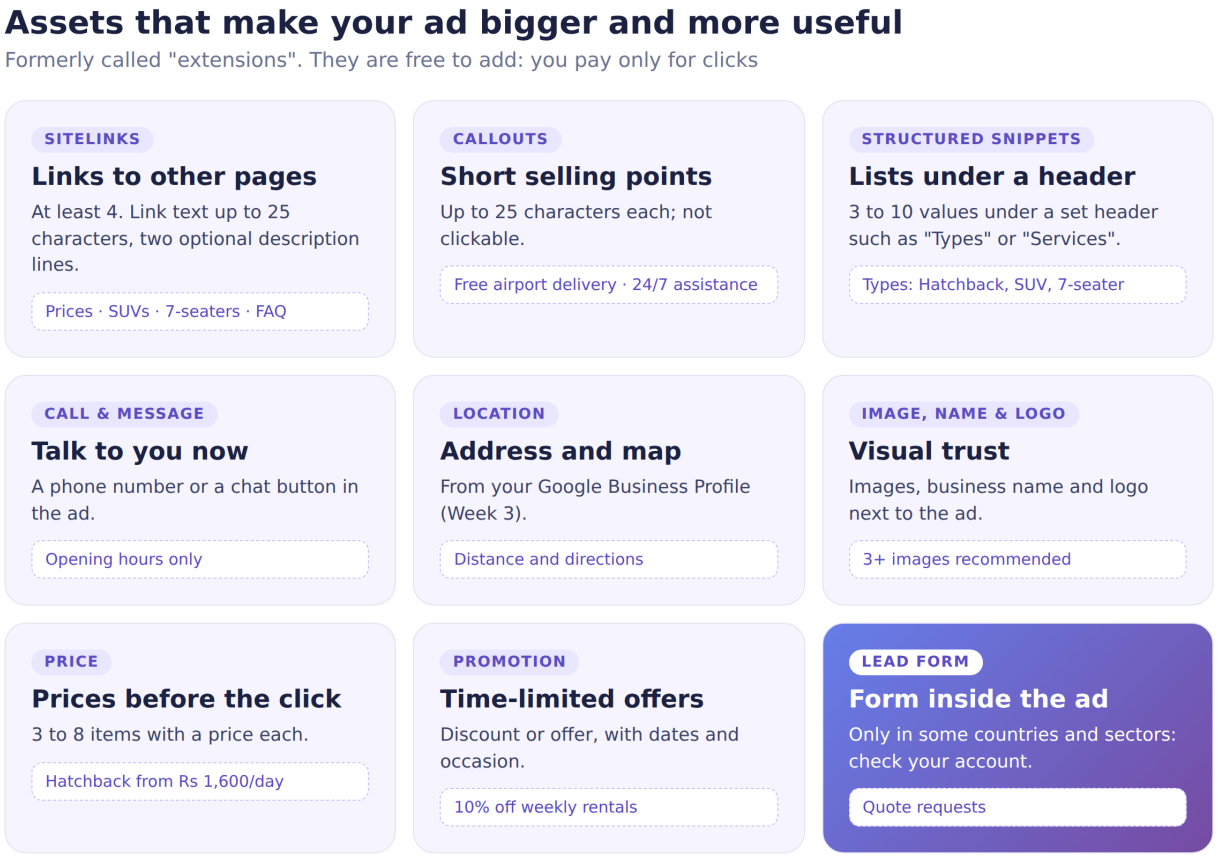
Before and after

Before (weak)	After (strong)
Welcome to PlomboFix	Emergency Plumber Curepipe
Best Plumbing Services	At Your Door in 60 Minutes
Call Us Now!!!	Call or WhatsApp 7 Days a Week
Quality Work	Fixed Price Quote Before Work

SECTION 20

Assets

Assets (called "extensions" until a few years ago) add extra information under your ad: links, phone numbers, prices, images. They make the ad bigger, more useful and more clickable, and they are part of Ad Rank. They are free to add; you pay only for clicks.



Assets every beginner should add

Asset	Limits and tips	Level
Sitelinks	At least 4 (Google's recommendation). Link text up to 25 characters; two optional description lines of 35 characters	Account or campaign
Callouts	Up to 25 characters each; add 4–8	Account or campaign
Structured snippets	A header (Types, Services, Destinations...) with 3 to 10 values of up to 25 characters	Campaign
Call	Your phone number; set a schedule for opening hours; track calls as conversions	Campaign
Location	Linked from your Google Business Profile (Week 3)	Account
Images	At least 3 unique, relevant images (Google's recommendation); real photos work best	Campaign or ad group
Business name and logo	Shown next to the ad when eligible; must match your website or registered name	Account

Other assets: **price** (3 to 8 items), **promotion** (discounts with dates), **message** (start a chat), **app** and **lead form** (available only in some countries and sectors; check your account).

Google decides which assets show for each search, based on what it expects to perform best. Adding more relevant assets gives it more choice. You manage them in **Campaigns** › **Assets**.

> **In Mauritius:** in a market where many people call or WhatsApp rather than fill in forms, the **call asset** and a **location asset** are often the most valuable. For tourism, a **price asset** with clear daily rates ("Hatchback from Rs 1,600/day") filters out bargain hunters before they click.

SECTION 21

Landing pages

The landing page is where the click becomes a customer, or not. A great ad sending people to a slow, generic home page wastes money. Landing page experience is also one of the three Quality Score components (Week 7 goes deeper).

The landing page checklist

- ☐ **Message match:** the page headline repeats the promise of the ad ("Car rental at SSR Airport, free delivery").
- ☐ **One page per ad group**, not the home page.
- ☐ **Fast on mobile:** Largest Contentful Paint under 2.5 seconds (Week 2).
- ☐ **The call to action above the fold:** Book now, Get a quote, Call, WhatsApp.
- ☐ **Price or "from" price** and what is included.
- ☐ **Proof:** Google reviews, photos of real cars, rooms or work, guarantees.
- ☐ **Short form:** only the fields you really need (name, phone, dates).
- ☐ **Conversion tracking tested** on this page (Section 10).
- ☐ **Policy basics:** contact details, privacy notice, no misleading claims (Section 26).

> **Tip:** if the client's website cannot create new pages quickly, a simple landing page builder or a well-designed WordPress page is enough. What matters is relevance, speed and a clear call to action, not a fancy design.

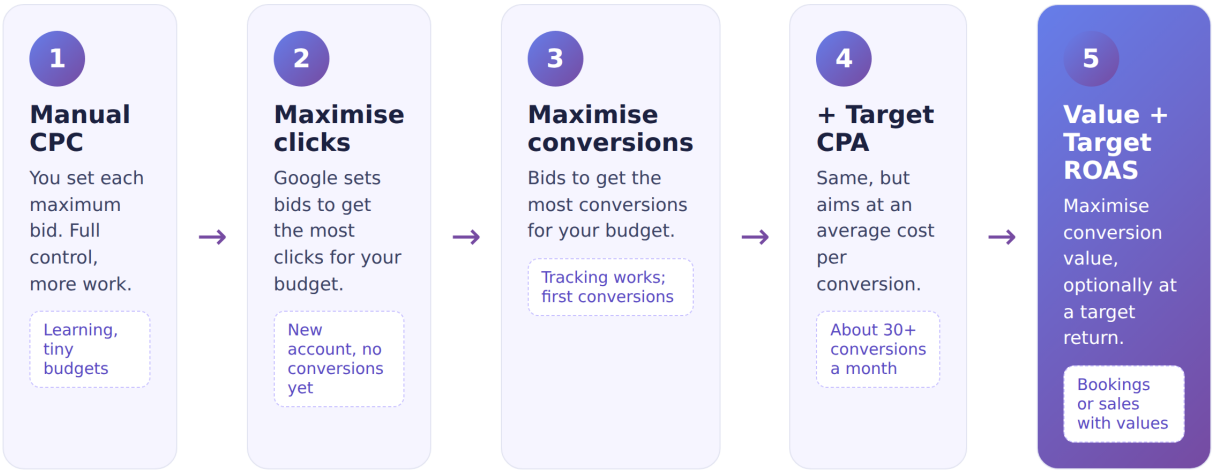
SECTION 22

Bidding strategies

The bid strategy tells Google how to set your bid in each auction. You can bid yourself (manual) or let Google’s AI bid for you towards a goal (automated or "Smart Bidding").

The bidding ladder: which strategy, when?

Move up as your conversion data grows



Strategy	Google optimises for	Needs	Use it when
Manual CPC	Nothing: you set each maximum CPC	Time and attention	Learning, very small budgets, full control
Maximise clicks	The most clicks within the budget (optional max CPC limit)	A budget	New campaign without conversion tracking or data
Maximise conversions	The most conversions within the budget	Working conversion tracking	First conversions are coming in
Maximise conversions + target CPA	As many conversions as possible at an average CPA you set	Steady conversion volume	You know your profitable CPA
Maximise conversion value	The most total value (revenue) within the budget	Conversion values	Bookings or sales with different values
Maximise conversion value + target ROAS	Value at an average return you set	Steady conversions with values	E-commerce, bookings with revenue
Target impression share	Showing at the top (or absolute top) a set % of the time	A budget	Brand campaigns; rarely for beginners

In the current interface, **Target CPA** is an optional setting inside Maximise conversions, and **Target ROAS** an optional setting inside Maximise conversion value.

Enhanced CPC is gone: Google removed Enhanced CPC (eCPC) for Search and Display campaigns from the week of 31 March 2025; campaigns still using it now behave as Manual CPC. If an old guide or a client account mentions it, choose another strategy.

How Smart Bidding works

Smart Bidding uses many signals at auction time: device, location, time, language, the exact search, the browser, remarketing lists and more. It can raise the bid for a search that looks likely to convert and lower it for one that doesn't. This is something no human can do by hand for every single auction. But it only learns from the conversions you track: wrong or missing tracking means wrong bidding.

The learning period

When you start or change a Smart Bidding strategy, Google shows a "Learning" status for a period (often around one to two weeks, longer with few conversions). Avoid big changes to budget, targets or ads during this time and judge results on at least two to four weeks of data.

SECTION 23

Choosing a bid strategy

There is no single best strategy, only the right one for your stage. Use this decision path for each new campaign.

1. **Is conversion tracking working and tested?** No → **Maximise clicks** with a maximum CPC limit (e.g. Rs 40) for 2–4 weeks while you fix tracking. Or Manual CPC if you want full control.
2. **Yes, but few conversions so far** (fewer than about 15–30 a month) → **Maximise conversions** without a target.
3. **Steady conversions** (about 30 or more a month) and a known profitable CPA → add a **target CPA**, starting close to your actual average CPA, then lower it gradually (by about 10–15% at a time).
4. **Conversions with real values** (revenue from bookings or sales) → **Maximise conversion value**, then add a **target ROAS** when volume is steady.
5. **Brand campaign** → Manual CPC, Maximise clicks or Target impression share, with a small budget.

The conversion thresholds above are rules of thumb used by practitioners, not official minimums: Google lets you use any strategy, but Smart Bidding performs better with more data.

Mauritian examples

Business	Month 1	Month 2–3	Later
PlomboFix (calls)	Maximise clicks, max CPC Rs 35; call conversions set up	Maximise conversions	Target CPA Rs 400 if 30+ calls a month
Ramdin & Co (forms)	Maximise conversions (tracking ready from day 1)	Maximise conversions	Target CPA once volume allows
Dodo Drive (bookings with value)	Maximise conversions	Maximise conversion value	Target ROAS (e.g. 800%)
Lagon Bleu (booking requests)	Manual CPC to learn the costs	Maximise conversions	Target CPA in high season

> **Tip:** a target CPA or ROAS that is too ambitious makes Google bid too low, so the campaign stops spending and you get almost no conversions. Start realistic, then tighten.

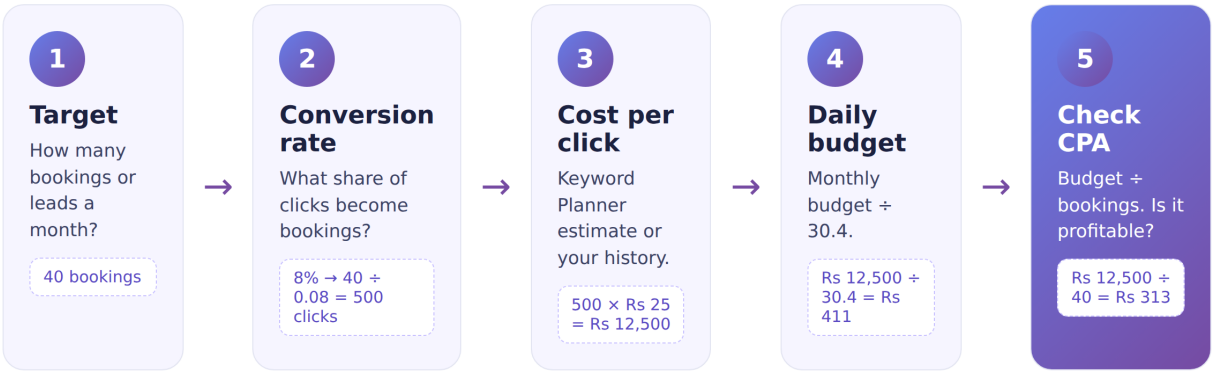
SECTION 24

Budget maths

A good marketer does not ask "how much should I spend?" but "how much do I need to spend to reach the target, and is it profitable?". Five formulas answer both questions.

From business target to daily budget

Work backwards from what you need (illustrative car-rental numbers)



The formulas

You want	Formula	Example
Clicks needed	Target conversions ÷ conversion rate	40 ÷ 8% = 500 clicks
Monthly budget	Clicks × average CPC	500 × Rs 25 = Rs 12,500
Daily budget	Monthly budget ÷ 30.4	Rs 12,500 ÷ 30.4 = Rs 411
Expected CPA	Budget ÷ conversions (= CPC ÷ CVR)	Rs 12,500 ÷ 40 = Rs 313 (= Rs 25 ÷ 0.08)
Break-even CPA	Average sale value × profit margin	Rs 9,000 × 30% = Rs 2,700
ROAS	Conversion value ÷ cost	40 × Rs 9,000 ÷ Rs 12,500 = 28.8 (2,880%)

All numbers are illustrative. Use Keyword Planner CPC ranges, your own history or a 2–4 week test to replace them.

Is it profitable?

Compare the expected CPA with the **break-even CPA**, the most you can pay for one customer before losing money. A 5-day car rental at Rs 1,800 a day is worth Rs 9,000; with a 30% margin, Dodo Drive earns Rs 2,700 per booking before advertising. A CPA of Rs 313 leaves plenty of profit. For a cake shop selling Rs 1,200 cakes at a 40% margin, the break-even CPA is only Rs 480, so the same CPC would need a much higher conversion rate.

Budget by ad group: a worked example (Dodo Drive)

Ad group	Target bookings	CVR	CPC (Rs)	Clicks	Monthly (Rs)	Daily (Rs)	CPA (Rs)
Airport car hire	20	10%	30	200	6,000	197	300
Cheap car rental	12	6%	20	200	4,000	132	333
SUV and 7-seater	8	8%	28	100	2,800	92	350
Total	**40**	**8%**	**25.6**	**500**	**12,800**	**421**	**320**

Budgets are set per campaign, so the ad group figures help you decide the campaign budget and check later which group is above or below plan. The Excel exercise (4th exercise) practises exactly this.

What if the budget is fixed?

If the owner says "I have Rs 8,000 a month", work forwards: Rs 8,000 ÷ Rs 25 = 320 clicks; 320 × 8% ≈ 26 bookings. Then decide whether to focus that money on the best ad group instead of spreading it thinly. A campaign "limited by budget" all month is losing searches every day.

> **Tip:** in very small markets, the problem can be the opposite: not enough searches to spend the budget. If Keyword Planner shows few searches, add related keywords, French versions, or targeting of source countries for tourism, before raising bids.

SECTION 25

Performance Max and AI Max: an introduction

Google is moving towards campaigns where AI decides more of the targeting and the ad text. You need to know what these are, even if your first campaign is a classic Search campaign.

	Search (classic)	AI Max for Search	Performance Max
What it is	Keywords you choose, ads you write	An option you switch on inside a Search campaign	A separate campaign type across all Google channels
Where ads show	Google Search (+ partners)	Google Search, including more queries	Search, YouTube, Display, Gmail, Maps, Discover
Targeting	Keywords and match types	Keywords + "search term matching" beyond them	Asset groups, audience signals, search themes
Control	High	Medium: brand, location and text controls	Lower; more reporting than before
Best for	Learning, local services, small budgets	Advertisers with good conversion data wanting more reach	Accounts with strong tracking, creative assets and budget

AI Max for Search in brief

AI Max is a set of features you can switch on in a Search campaign. Google describes three parts:

- **Search term matching:** finds relevant searches beyond your keywords, using your ads and website.
- **Text customisation:** writes ad text adapted to each search, which you can steer with text guidelines.

- **Final URL expansion:** sends people to the page of your website that best fits their search.

Google announced in 2026 that Dynamic Search Ads (DSA), automatically created assets and the campaign-level broad match setting are being upgraded to AI Max. Automatic upgrades for automatically created assets and campaign-level broad match were scheduled from September 2026; for DSA, Google extended the timetable to begin in February 2027. In the search terms report, matches found by AI Max appear with "AI Max" as the match type.

What it means for you this week

- Learn on a classic Search campaign first: you need to understand keywords, search terms and negatives to judge what AI finds.
- Keep AI Max off at first, unless your account already has reliable conversion tracking and enough conversions.
- When you test it, use an **experiment** (half the traffic with AI Max, half without) and check the search terms and landing pages it chooses.
- Performance Max is not a shortcut for beginners: without good conversion tracking it can spend on low-quality placements. Week 7 and later weeks come back to it.

PART E

Launch & measure

Google Ads policies, the launch checklist, your first 30 days and the reports to read

SECTION 26

Google Ads policies: the basics

Every ad, keyword, asset and landing page is reviewed against Google Ads policies, by automated systems and sometimes by people. Most reviews take less than a business day. Knowing the main rules avoids disapproved ads and suspended accounts.

Policy area	What it covers	Examples
Prohibited content	Never allowed	Counterfeit goods, dangerous products (weapons, recreational drugs), content that enables dishonest behaviour, inappropriate content
Prohibited practices	How you advertise	Misrepresentation (hiding fees, false claims, fake urgency), abusing the ad network, collecting data without care, trying to get around reviews
Restricted content	Allowed with limits or certification	Alcohol, gambling, healthcare and medicines, financial services, legal services, political content
Editorial and technical	Quality and format	No ALL CAPS or "!!!", correct spelling, a working landing page, matching display URL domain, no phone numbers in ad text (use a call asset)

Ad statuses you will see

Status	Meaning	What to do
Under review	Google is checking the ad	Wait (usually less than a business day)
Eligible	The ad can run	Nothing
Eligible (limited)	Runs, but not everywhere or not for everyone, because of a policy restriction	Read the reason; fix if possible
Disapproved	Cannot run	Hover over the status, read the policy, fix the ad or page, then resubmit or appeal

Common reasons beginners get disapproved

- **Destination not working:** the landing page is down, too slow, redirects strangely or blocks Google’s crawler.
- **Editorial:** excessive capitals ("BEST PRICES"), repeated punctuation, emojis or symbols used as gimmicks.
- **Unverifiable claims:** "No. 1 in Mauritius" or "Cheapest guaranteed" without proof on the page.
- **Trademarks:** using another company’s brand name in ad text when it is restricted.
- **Restricted sectors:** financial services (loans, investments), healthcare and gambling often need extra certification or verification.

Account suspensions are serious: they can affect the business’s ability to advertise for a long time. Never try to get around a disapproval with a new account, misleading text or a "cloaked" page. Fix the issue and appeal through the Policy manager.

In Mauritius: apply the same honesty in your ads as the Consumer Protection rules in Mauritius require in shops: the price in the ad must be the real price, "free delivery" must really be free, and an offer must have clear conditions on the landing page.

SECTION 27

Launch and your first 30 days

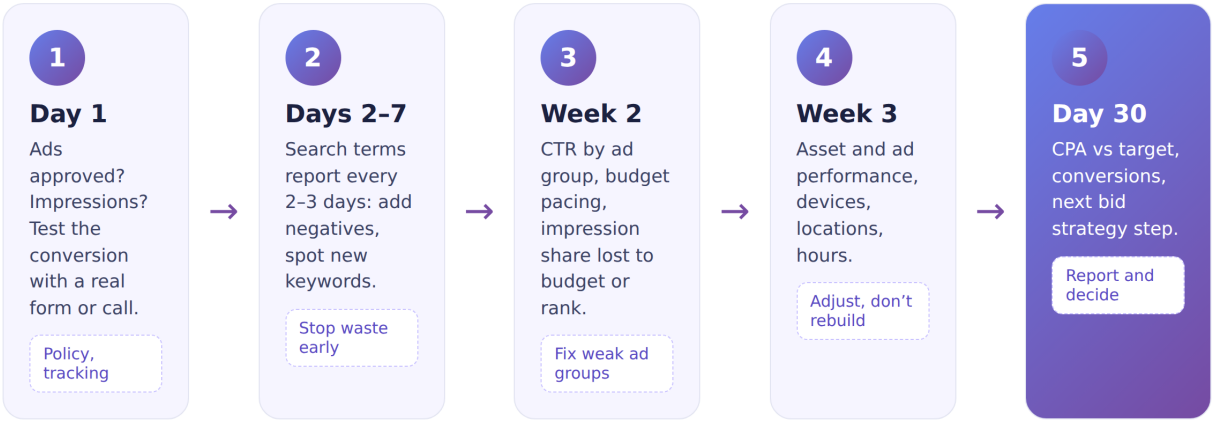
Launching is not the end of the job, it is the start. The first month is when you learn which searches, ads and pages work, and when the biggest savings are made.

Pre-launch checklist

- ☐ Account: business login, 2 admins, 2-step verification, billing and backup card, advertiser verification started.
- ☐ Tracking: conversion actions created, primary vs secondary set, tested ("Recording conversions"), GA4 linked, auto-tagging on.
- ☐ Campaign: Search only (partners and Display unticked), locations and location option checked, English + French, budget and bid strategy set.
- ☐ Ad groups: 3 tight themes, 5–20 keywords each in phrase or exact match, correct final URLs.
- ☐ Negatives: campaign list added (jobs, free, DIY, wrong products).
- ☐ Ads: 2 RSAs per ad group, Good or Excellent Ad Strength, every claim true on the page.
- ☐ Assets: 4+ sitelinks, 4+ callouts, structured snippet, call, location, images, business name and logo.
- ☐ Landing pages: fast on mobile, message match, clear call to action, tested on a phone.
- ☐ Reporting: a simple weekly tracking sheet or Data Studio report (Week 2).

The first 30 days after launch

Small, regular checks beat big, panicked changes



The search terms report

Keywords are what you bid on; **search terms** are what people actually typed. Open **Campaigns › Insights and reports › Search terms**. For each term, decide:

- **Add as keyword:** relevant terms that convert or get clicks at a good cost (add them in the right ad group, usually phrase or exact).
- **Add as negative:** irrelevant terms ("car rental jobs", "used car for sale", "free car rental"). Click the term, choose "Add as negative keyword" at ad group or campaign level.
- **Keep monitoring:** relevant terms with too little data to judge.

Some searches are hidden for privacy reasons when very few people typed them, so the report never shows 100% of your cost.

The metrics to read each week

Metric	Question it answers	Warning sign
Impressions	Are we showing?	Very low: keywords too narrow, bids too low or ads disapproved
CTR	Is the ad attractive and relevant?	Much lower than in your other ad groups: check ad relevance and search terms
Average CPC	How expensive is a click?	Far above plan: competition, low quality or broad terms
Conversions and CVR	Do clicks become customers?	Clicks but no conversions: tracking, landing page or wrong searches
CPA / ROAS	Is it profitable?	CPA above break-even (Section 24)
Search impression share	How many available searches did we show for?	Lost to budget: raise budget or narrow; lost to rank: improve quality or bids

Benchmarks vary a lot by sector and country: compare your own ad groups and months with each other rather than with a generic average.

Optimisation rules for beginners

- Change one thing at a time and write it down (date, change, reason) in a change log.
- Wait for enough data: at least 100 clicks on an ad group or 2 weeks before judging it.
- Pause what clearly wastes money (keywords with many clicks and no conversions), add negatives every week, and move budget to the best ad group.
- Week 7 covers deeper optimisation: Quality Score improvement, ad testing, audiences and experiments.

Recommendations and the optimisation score

Google shows an optimisation score and recommendations ("Raise your budget", "Add broad match", "Use AI Max"). Some are useful (fix a disapproved ad, add sitelinks), others mainly increase spend. Read each one and accept only what fits your plan. You can also turn off auto-apply recommendations in **Recommendations › Auto-apply**.

PART F

Put it to work

A car-rental case study, your Campaign Blueprint, templates and checklists

SECTION 28

Case study: a car rental’s first search campaign

"Dodo Drive" is a fictional but realistic car-rental company in Plaine Magnien, five minutes from SSR International Airport, with 35 cars. Its old Smart campaign, set up by a nephew, spent Rs 15,000 a month and brought "a few calls". The owner wanted online bookings from tourists.

1. The audit

- A Smart campaign with the keyword theme "car", sending all clicks to the home page.
- No conversion tracking; the booking engine was not linked to GA4.
- Ads shown in Mauritius only, with "Presence": tourists in France and the UK never saw them before the trip.
- Search terms (limited data) included "car for sale", "car loan" and "driving school".

2. The new set-up

Element	Decision
Goal	40 online bookings a month at a CPA under Rs 500 (break-even CPA: Rs 2,700)
Tracking	Booking confirmation as a GA4 key event with value (imported as primary); WhatsApp clicks and calls as secondary
Campaigns	Search | Car rental | EN (UK, South Africa, Mauritius) and Search | Location voiture | FR (France, Reunion, Mauritius), with "Presence or interest"
Ad groups	Airport car hire · Cheap car rental · SUV and 7-seater (same three in French)
Keywords	42 phrase and exact keywords; 60 negatives (jobs, sale, loan, school, licence…)
Ads and assets	2 RSAs per ad group; sitelinks, callouts, price, call, location, images
Landing pages	Three new pages with prices and a "Book in 2 minutes" button
Bidding and budget	Maximise clicks (max CPC Rs 40) for 2 weeks, then Maximise conversions; Rs 13,000 a month

3. Results after 8 weeks (illustrative)

KPI	Smart campaign (before)	Search campaigns (weeks 5–8)
Monthly cost	Rs 15,000	Rs 13,200
Clicks per month	610	540
CTR	1.9%	7.4%
Average CPC	Rs 25	Rs 24
Online bookings	Not tracked (owner’s estimate: 5)	43
CPA	Unknown	Rs 307
Revenue from bookings	Unknown	Rs 391,000 (ROAS 2,960%)

What made the difference: tracking first, targeting tourists before they travel, tight ad groups with matching landing pages, and weekly search-term cleaning. The French campaign had a lower CTR but the highest average booking value (longer rentals).

> **The lesson:** the budget did not change much. The structure, the targeting and the measurement did. Google Ads rewards relevance and punishes vagueness.

SECTION 29

Exercises and your Campaign Blueprint

Your Week 6 deliverable is a **Campaign Blueprint**: a functional Search campaign plan with 3 ad groups, keywords, ads and bids configured. Work on a real business (your own, your employer's or one you know well) or on one of the fictional businesses in this guide.

Exercise A · Account and tracking plan (30 min)

Using Sections 6–10, write the account structure (campaign and ad group names), the primary and secondary conversions, how each will be tracked (Google tag or GA4 key event) and who will have admin access.

Exercise B · Keyword research and ad groups (60 min)

In Keyword Planner (Section 14), with the right location and languages, collect 40–60 ideas. Keep 8–15 per ad group for 3 ad groups, choose a match type for each (Section 15), and write a negative list of at least 20 words (Section 16). Note average monthly searches and the top-of-page bid range.

Exercise C · Ads, assets and budget (60 min)

Write one RSA per ad group with 10–15 headlines and 4 descriptions within the limits (Sections 18–19), 4 sitelinks, 4 callouts and one structured snippet (Section 20). Calculate the budget from a target (Section 24) and choose a bid strategy with a reason (Section 23).

Optional: build it in Google Ads

If you have access to an account, build the campaign and leave it **paused**, or launch it with the business owner's approval and a small budget. Never launch with someone else's card without written agreement.

Deliverable: the Campaign Blueprint

Part	Content
1. Business, goal and target	Summary, primary conversion, monthly target, break-even CPA
2. Account and tracking	Structure, conversions, links (GA4, Search Console), access
3. Campaign settings	Networks, locations and option, languages, schedule, budget, bid strategy
4. Three ad groups	Theme, landing page, 8–15 keywords with match types
5. Negative keywords	At least 20, by theme and level
6. Ads	One RSA per ad group (10–15 headlines, 4 descriptions, paths)
7. Assets	Sitelinks, callouts, structured snippet, call/location, images
8. Budget maths and launch plan	Clicks, budget, CPA, daily budget; pre-launch checklist; first-30-days plan

Submit the Blueprint (Google Sheet, Google Doc or PDF link) on the learning platform, Module 6 exercises. The Excel exercise (6.4) practises keyword grouping, budget maths, RSA writing and the search terms report on a fictional car-rental business.

TEMPLATES

Copy-and-use templates

Ad group plan (one per ad group)

Field	Your answer
Ad group name	
Theme / intent	
Landing page URL	
Keywords and match types (8–15)	
Ad group negatives	
Avg. monthly searches (total)	
Top-of-page bid range (Rs)	

Responsive search ad

#	Headline (max 30)	Chars	#	Headline (max 30)	Chars
1			9		
2			10		
3			11		
4			12		
5			13		
6			14		
7			15		
8					

#	Description (max 90)	Chars
1		
2		
3		
4		
Paths	/ (max 15) / (max 15)	

Budget calculator

Ad group	Target conv.	CVR	CPC (Rs)	Clicks = conv. ÷ CVR	Monthly = clicks × CPC	Daily = monthly ÷ 30.4	CPA = monthly ÷ conv.
1							
2							
3							
Total							

SECTION 30

Checklists, mistakes and glossary

Weekly routine

- ☐ Check spend vs budget and any disapproved ads or billing alerts.
- ☐ Search terms report: add negatives and new keywords.
- ☐ Compare ad groups: CTR, CPC, conversions, CPA.
- ☐ Check conversion tracking still records (no sudden drop to zero).
- ☐ Review recommendations; accept only what fits the plan.
- ☐ Write every change in the change log.

Mistakes to avoid

Mistake	Do this instead
Running a Smart campaign without knowing it	Expert Mode, Search campaign
Launching without conversion tracking	Track and test conversions first
Keeping Display and search partners ticked by default	Search Network only at first
"Presence or interest" for a local plumber	"Presence" with a radius
One ad group with 80 keywords	3–5 tight ad groups, 5–20 keywords each
Broad match with Manual CPC and no negatives	Phrase/exact first; broad with Smart Bidding and negatives
Sending every ad to the home page	One relevant landing page per ad group
Accepting every recommendation	Judge each one against your goal
Changing everything every day	One change at a time, enough data

Glossary

Term	Meaning
Ad Rank	The score that decides if and where an ad shows: bid, quality, thresholds, competition, context, assets
Ad group	A set of keywords with one theme and the ads written for them
Ad Strength	Rating of how varied and relevant an RSA’s headlines and descriptions are
AI Max for Search	Search campaign features: search term matching, text customisation, final URL expansion
Asset	Extra information in an ad (sitelink, callout, call, location, image...), formerly "extension"
Auto-tagging	Adds a click ID (gclid) to ad URLs so GA4 can attribute visits to Google Ads
Break-even CPA	The highest cost per customer before losing money: sale value × margin
CPA, CPC, CTR, CVR	Cost per acquisition, cost per click, click-through rate, conversion rate
Expert Mode	The full Google Ads interface, as opposed to Smart campaigns
Impression share	Impressions received ÷ impressions you were eligible for
Key event	A GA4 event marked as important; can be imported into Google Ads as a conversion
Match type	How closely a search must match a keyword: broad, phrase, exact
Negative keyword	A word or phrase that stops ads showing for certain searches
Performance Max	An AI-driven campaign type across all Google channels
Pinning	Fixing a headline or description to a position in an RSA
Quality Score	A 1–10 keyword diagnostic: expected CTR, ad relevance, landing page experience
ROAS	Return on ad spend: conversion value ÷ cost
RSA	Responsive search ad: up to 15 headlines and 4 descriptions combined by Google
Search term	The actual words someone typed that triggered your ad
Smart Bidding	Automated bid strategies that optimise for conversions or value